
**Research Assignment:
A Site History of an American Designed Landscape**

Your task is to write a concise yet thorough site history of an American designed landscape, broadly defined (e.g. a park, square, garden, town plan, suburban plan, forest reserve, national park, land art, trail system, wildlife preserve, etc.). You should research and discuss the origins, concept, and design (broadly defined) of the site and how this work is connected to the historical trends and contexts in class and readings. If the site is local, you should plan to visit the site in order to form your own impressions and record its current state in photographs. Because the designed landscape encompasses everything that is not a building, the subject of your research assignment can reflect this wide-ranging definition—any landscape of any location and size is an acceptable subject. Undergraduate students who are doing senior theses may use this paper to research and write a section of their thesis. Graduate students may use this assignment to research an aspect of their chosen or potential thesis or professional report topic.

You should guide the writing and interpretation of your research around a thesis and themes. The questions you need to ask are at least the following: What existed on the site before its current condition? How did this landscape come about? How and why was this particular piece of property set aside for this particular purpose? What were the aesthetic and non-aesthetic considerations in forming the landscape--the practical, social, economic, political and cultural forces which shaped it? (Sometimes, if not often, these are more forceful than aesthetic issues.) What was the process of design and implementation? What has been the influence and legacy of this work of landscape architecture? Did it influence other sites in the landscape? Why or why not? How does it fit into a larger scheme or idea for the landscape of city, suburb, countryside, or wilderness?

Historians, writers, journalists, documentarians, and passionate amateurs have so extensively written about the following sites that they are **excluded from possible research topics: Central Park in New York City, Yosemite National Park, Yellowstone National Park, Golden Gate Park in San Francisco, and the Japanese Tea Garden in Golden Gate Park.** Culling through that much material is not feasible within the time frame of the class.

The purpose of this assignment is to record and collect information, usually scattered material, into a single informative **illustrated text**. You can think of your report as an entry in a well-researched, authoritatively sourced, and insightful survey book on American landscape sites.

For your research, you have access to the physical library as well as a vast array of online sources. There are now an extraordinary number of digitized materials, both contemporary and historical (such as the archives of major newspapers) through the library, plus many reliable websites devoted landscape history, collections of digitized archival material including those from the Environmental Design Archives and the Library of Congress. This includes prodigious archives of historical images which are often excellent primary sources.

A research session by CED Librarian Andrew Matsas will introduce you to library research regarding the history of American landscape architecture.

Essential software/apps for you to download for free in order to complete this assignment:

Microsoft 365 (Word, Excel, etc)

<https://software.berkeley.edu/microsoft-365>

It is now possible to **log in to library website through your CalNet ID**. In some cases, though, you might need **Global Protect Secure VPN** for accessing the LIBRARY online resources from off campus and the many digital resources accessed through the library.

<https://software.berkeley.edu/bsecure-remote-access-vpn>

GoogleEarthPro an incredible resource for looking at the landscapes as they have digitized numerous historical aerials and georeferenced contemporary aerials to historical maps.

<https://www.google.com/earth/download/gep/agree.html?hl=en-GB>

Citation management tools are available through the library website. This will make correct and thorough citations of your sources much easier.

<https://guides.lib.berkeley.edu/cite-your-sources>

Louise Mazingo and the LA171 GSI Shrabya Timsina are also available to help you with every aspect of your paper from choosing a subject, to content, to formatting.

Use of AI

Since research, writing, analytical, and critical thinking skills are part of the learning outcomes of this course, the research assignment must be prepared by the student. **Use of AI should be limited to grammar and spelling checks, or other minor supporting roles, and you should cite the AI program and specify how it has been used in the research assignment.** You may not use AI to generate content, summarize articles or scholarly debates, or produce images. AI tools are also known for serious “hallucinations,” ranging from incorrect historical events to fabricated scholarly references. This is especially true of landscape topics—many sites are incorrectly characterized in AI summaries with false dates, associated historical figures, and incorrect images, contexts, or locations. In line with the University’s guidelines, any suspicion of AI-generated content will be treated as plagiarism. See <https://writing.berkeley.edu/academic-honesty>

Research Report Requirements

1. **The site must have been substantially completed by 1990 while recognizing that sites are ever evolving.** LA/AS 171 is a history course and the intent is for you to do historical research, not a critique of a contemporary project. (Yes, this means you cannot do the Highline in New York City.)
2. Cite at least seven sources other than general texts. These can include interviews. **Your sources must include three primary sources. Note that historical photographs and maps are primary sources for interpretation, as are historical newspaper articles.**
3. Include **images (present day and historic ones) a location map, and a site plan view with a scale and north arrow** to illustrate your essay. (GoogleEarth now makes this pretty easy, including links to historical maps.) The **illustrations should be integrated into the text** not grouped at the end.
4. The text (excluding footnotes, bibliography, and illustration captions) must be no less than 2500 words, approximately 8 pages, and no more than 4500 words, approximately 15 pages.
5. The report should include three sections:
 - **A short introduction** providing *orientation to the subject and the thesis* of the paper.
 - **The body** of the text that presents your research and its thesis and themes.
 - **A conclusion** that discusses significance, meaning and relevance. *This is the most interpretive part of the text and the one that students most often leave out.*

8. Provide **complete citations** for the text in footnotes and for illustrations in captions, plus an **annotated bibliography in the final paper**. The use of the **Chicago Manual of Style footnote and bibliography citation style is a requirement**. Please note that if you use **online sources, you must include an access date for the citation to be complete**. An abbreviated guide to this citation style prepared by the UC Library is available on the class bCourse site. The full guide is available online through the UC Library website at:
<http://www.chicagomanualofstyle.org/16/contents.html>
9. **Cite the AI programs used in the research assignment for spelling and grammar checks—the only legitimate use of AI in this class**—at the end of the text and before the bibliography.
9. PDF format consists of a simple cover page with title, name, course, and date;
 8 1/2 x 11 format with 1 inch margins on all sides; 12 point double-spaced text uploaded onto bCourses.
10. Please note that we will be **checking each paper with Turnitin**. For details on Turnitin see
<https://dls.berkeley.edu/services/academic-integrity/turnitin-students-getting-started>

Due dates

All materials for the research assignment should be turned in by uploading onto appropriate bCourse site. **See a helpful document on bCourse, “Research Paper: Proposal, Thesis Statement, Citation Style, and Annotated Bibliography** for guidance on choosing a topic, writing a topic proposal, forming a thesis statement, citation style, and putting together an annotated bibliography. The due dates for the research report are divided into three parts:

1. A **topic proposal** due uploaded onto bCourses by **6pm 9/25/26**. This is a four to six sentence description of the site you would like to research, its location, what type of landscape it is (i.e. a park, urban plaza, suburban plan, a national forest, wilderness area etc., a trail system, a Native American reservation), and the date of its initial establishment.
2. A **progress report** due uploaded onto bCourses **by 6pm 10/30/26**. This includes:
 - **description of your research methods thus far** (archival search, archive visit, site visit planned or completed, reference librarian consultation, completed or planned interviews),
 - **a thesis statement**
 - **a descriptive list of themes** you intend to explore as part of your thesis
 - **an initial annotated bibliography** in the correct Chicago Manual of Style format
3. The completed pdf of the **research assignment with complete citations, AI citation, and annotated bibliography, uploaded by 12 noon 11/25/26**

Some suggestions

1. Spend some time thinking about the final product presentation. A well thought out paper will look professional and be an added bonus to your portfolio or to your resume. Integrate maps, illustrations, etc. within the text on one smooth layout. Think of the paper in its entirety, as a cohesive unit.
2. Set up an appointment with a CED librarian about your topic.
3. The number of digital collections of historic maps and photographs are prodigious. Start with Google image search, then specialized collections. U.S. Sanborn maps (insurance maps) show details of land use change over time and are available online through "Electronics Resources" of the UCB library. The San Francisco and Oakland public libraries have extraordinary collections on Bay Area history, including historic photographs. The Online Archive of California <https://oac.cdlib.org>, the Library of Congress <https://www.loc.gov/pictures/>, and the Rumsey Collection <https://www.davidrumsey.com> have excellent historic photographs and maps. Many specialized image collections are available through the UCB Library such as ARTstor.
4. If designers and clients are still alive, be persistent about getting to talk to them. People love talking about the work that they have done or commissioned. Do not be intimidated.
5. Once you collect your research, start with an outline; it makes everything easier.
6. The paper writing process is one of write, edit, and correct. A longer paper is not necessarily better, hence the word limit.
7. If English is your second language, have a person for whom English is their first language read the paper.
8. **Avoid the passive voice!** (A pet peeve of the professor.)
 - The garden trellis was changed in 1924. (passive voice) vs. Agnes Delgado changed the garden trellis in 1924. (active voice)
 - The park pavilion was used for a dance 1938. (passive voice) vs. In 1938, the Tartanettes, a Nisei social club, used the park pavilion for a dance. (active voice)
9. The excuse "my computer crashed" or and other excuses of that ilk are in the category of "my dog ate my homework." Back up your work.
10. We can read an early draft of the paper and provide comments and suggestions.
11. If you write your paper for more than one course you must let the instructors know otherwise you will receive an "F" for the paper.

Evaluation Criteria

1. The text is the right length and is grammatically correct.
2. The report demonstrates thorough research based numerous credible sources, correctly cited, and original observations.
3. The report presents research in an organized manner that creates a coherent narrative. It does not jump randomly from subject to subject.
4. The report develops a thesis and themes and includes an original, thoughtful conclusion.
5. Citations are correct and complete (including page numbers!) using the required citation style.
6. The report includes at least the required illustrations and illustrations are correctly described and cited.
7. The format of the report follows guidelines for margins, font, and integrated illustrations.
8. Timeliness. **Late papers will be graded down.** For every class period 1/3 grade down plus for every weekend 1/3 grade down. **No papers turned in after the last day of classes will be graded** except in cases of extreme unexpected circumstance.

If plagiarism (including use of AI to generate content) is suspected students will be referred to the University Center for Student Conduct. Should it be determined that plagiarism did take place you will receive an “F” for the course, no exceptions. Information on the Berkeley Code of Student Conduct is available at: [UC Berkeley Academic Honor Code](https://guides.library.ucla.edu/citing/plagiarism/avoid) For additional information on plagiarism and how to avoid it:

<https://guides.library.ucla.edu/citing/plagiarism/avoid>